announcement that he would contest the June 2022 Rajya Sabha election that began the unravelling of the MVA government. The Shiv Sena had declined to support him and fielded party leader Sanjay Pawar. Though Sambhajiraje backed off, Pawar saw a shock defeat at the hands of Dhananjay Mahadik of the BJP in an election that saw massive cross-voting. Later that month, Eknath Shinde walked out with his legislators to topple the MVA.

Meanwhile, reports say Sambhajiraje's father Chhatrapati Shahu-II is not too happy with the developments. He had opposed his son's BJP-backed Rajya Sabha appointment in 2016 too. Sambhaji's brother Malojiraje, a former Congress MLA, is still with the party. Shahu himself had briefly flirted with the Shiv Sena in the 1990s.

THE EX-ROYAL HASN'T BEEN LUCKY AT THE HUSTINGS. HE LOST THE 2009 LS POLL DESPITE TAILWINDS FROM THE MARATHA QUOTA UNREST

A former associate of Sambhajiraje notes that he had lost the 2009 Lok Sabha election from Kolhapur as an NCP nominee despite the tailwinds of the Maratha quota unrest. Groups like the Maratha Seva Sangh and Sambhaji Brigade had catalysed Sambhajiraje's entry into politics through these protests in 2007-8. "But now these organisations are considerably weaker... (and) there is a perception that Swarajya will work to the BJP's favour," he noted, adding that leaders of the BJP and the Shinde Shiv Sena may be aiding the ex-royal. "It will not be a surprise if Sambhajiraje is given a significant position by Shinde," he claimed. The social divide between the Marathas and the OBCs, who compete for dominance in local politics, would also restrict the party's electoral catchment area, the ex-royalist added. ■



TEETHING TROUBLES
A cheetah at the Kuno National Park, June 6

CHEETAHS IN KUNO

A SPOTTY TRAJECTORY

By Rahul Noronha

For a plan that took five decades from conception to fruition, the expectations surrounding Project Cheetah—dubbed as the first intercontinental translocation of a large wild carnivore—are bound to be high. But after a promising start, with Prime Minister Narendra Modi releasing eight cheetahs brought from Namibia at Kuno National Park in Madhya Pradesh last September, the fanfare has given way to an appreciation of starker realities. Mortality among the spotted felines has led to a re-evaluation of the whole project.

The first death was reported in late March—a female, Sasha, dying of "renal complications". But it was soon followed by the news of the birth of four cubs—a first after the big cat was declared extinct in India seven decades ago. The cheer was shortlived, though. In April, Uday, a male cheetah among the lot of 12 that had arrived from South Africa in February, died of "cardio pulmonary failure". And then, on May 9, Daksha, another female cheetah, was killed in a "violent mating interaction" with two males. But there was more bad news to come, as in late May, three cubs were lost in quick succession. The lone remaining one, though, is showing signs of recovery and has even gained weight since.